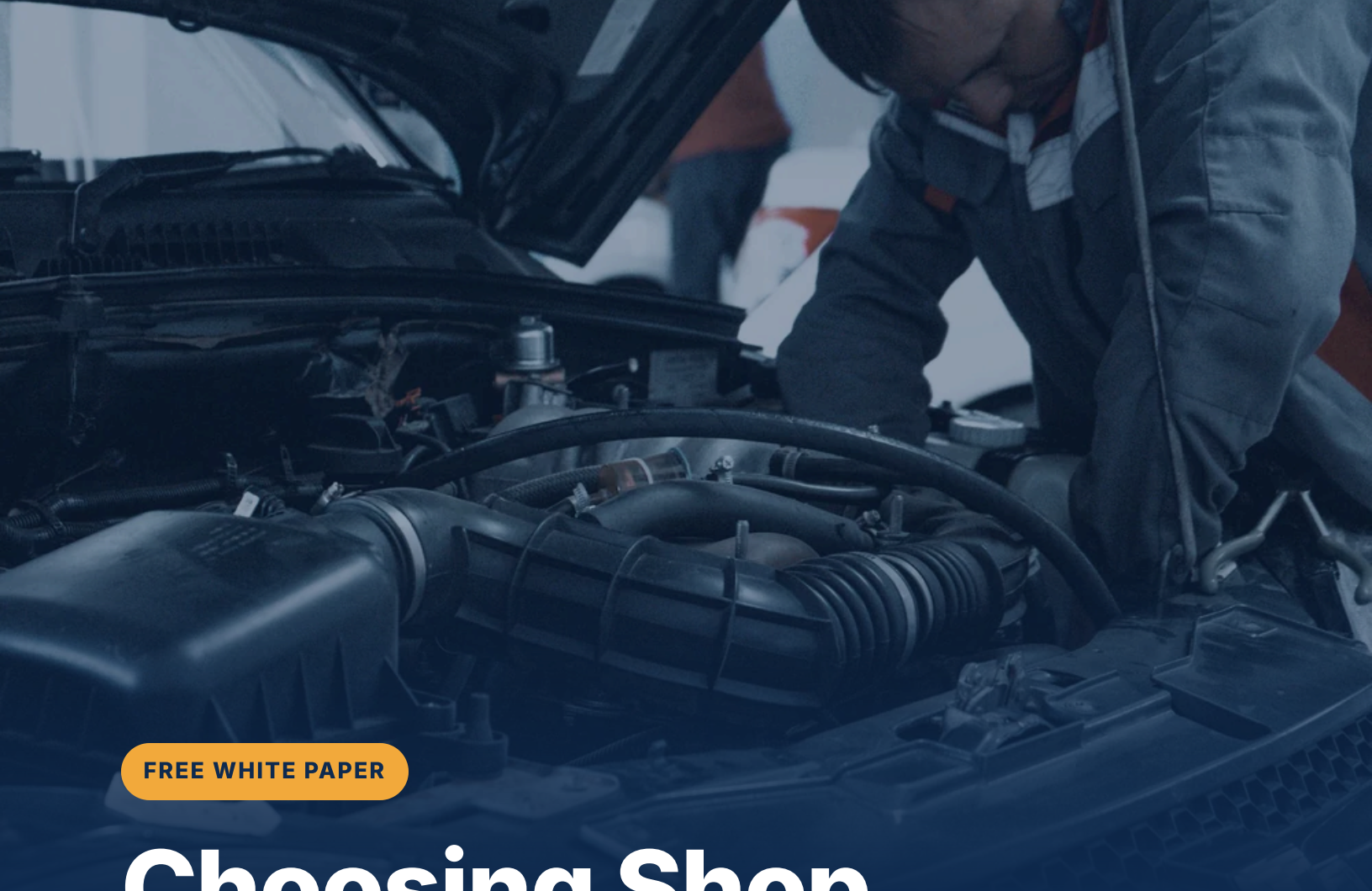


FREE WHITE PAPER

Choosing Shop Software: A Buyer's Checklist

The questions to ask any vendor before you sign, the red flags to watch for, and a scorecard to compare them side by side.

For independent auto repair shops with ten technicians or fewer.

XSite Auto xsiteauto.com

BEFORE YOU START

The right software pays for itself in the first month.

The wrong software costs you twice: once in fees, and again in the weeks your shop spends fighting it. Most owners buy after one demo, and find out what they really signed up for afterwards.

This checklist covers the ten things that matter most to a small independent shop. Each section has the questions to ask, the red flags to listen for, and what a good answer sounds like. Take it into every demo and use the scorecard at the back to compare vendors side by side.

We make shop software ourselves, so at the bottom of each section you'll see how XSite Auto answers. Ask every vendor the same questions, us included. A good vendor will be glad you asked.

01 **The real cost, not the monthly price**
Money

02 **Contracts and cancelling**
Commitment

03 **Your data stays yours**
Ownership

04 **Getting started**
Setup

05 **It fits the way you work**
Day to day

06 **It helps you get customers**
Growth

07 **It runs the whole day**
Workflow

08 **It works with your accounting**
QuickBooks

09 **Support from real people**
Help

10 **Try it before you buy it**
The trial

1 OF 10 · MONEY

The real cost, not the monthly price

The number on the pricing page is rarely what you end up paying. Setup fees, charges per technician or per login, paid add-ons and price increases can double the real cost over a couple of years.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. What will I pay in total for the first year, including setup, for a shop my size?
2. Is the price per shop, per technician or per login? What happens when I hire someone?
3. Which features cost extra? Is online booking, the website or support an add-on?
4. Are there fees on payments, text messages or storage?
5. How much has the price gone up in the last few years, and how much notice do I get?

RED FLAGS

- The salesperson can't give you a first-year total in writing.
- Key features you saw in the demo are on a higher plan.

What good looks like: One price for the shop, in writing, with everything you saw in the demo included.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** One price per shop: $99 USD or $139 CAD a month, with online booking, the website, hosting and support included. Setup is optional.

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2 OF 10 · COMMITMENT

Contracts and cancelling

Software that works for you doesn't need a long contract to keep you. A long term with automatic renewal mostly protects the vendor.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Is there a minimum term? Does it renew automatically?
2. How do I cancel, and how much notice do I need to give?
3. Is there a fee for cancelling early?
4. Can I try it with my real work before I commit?

RED FLAGS

- A 12 or 24-month term with a cancellation fee.
- Auto-renewal buried in the fine print.

What good looks like: Month to month, cancel any time, and a real trial before you pay anything.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** Month to month with no contract, and a free 14-day trial with no credit card.

3 OF 10 · OWNERSHIP

Your data stays yours

Your customer list and job history are among the most valuable things your shop owns. Before you put them into any system, know how you'd get them back out.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Can I download all my customers, vehicles and jobs whenever I want, without asking?
2. In what format? Will it open in Excel?
3. What happens to my data if I cancel?
4. How often is it backed up, and where is it stored?

RED FLAGS

- Exports only on request, for a fee, or only after you cancel.
- A vague answer about backups.

What good looks like: A download button you can use any day, in a format your accountant can open.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** Download a full backup of your records from Settings at any time. Your data is backed up and every change is kept in a change history.

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4 OF 10 · SETUP

Getting started

The most expensive part of new software is often the weeks it takes to set up. Ask exactly what it takes to go from signing up to running a real day.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. How long until I can run a normal day on it?
2. Can I bring my customers over from QuickBooks? How long does that take?
3. Who does the setup: me, or your team? What does that cost?
4. Is training included? For how many people?

RED FLAGS

- "Implementation" measured in weeks, with a project fee.
- Starting with an empty system and typing customers in by hand.

What good looks like: Running within a day, with your customers already in it, and help if you want it.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** Import your QuickBooks customers in minutes, or have our team do the whole setup and train your staff for $495 USD or $695 CAD, one time.

5 OF 10 · DAY TO DAY

It fits the way you work

Big-shop software is built for service advisors behind a counter all day. In a small shop, the owner may be checking the schedule from under a car. The software has to fit that.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Does it work on a phone and a tablet, or only on a desktop computer?
2. Is it built for shops my size, or for chains and dealers?
3. Does it handle my tax, currency and units properly?
4. How many clicks does it take to book a job, write it up and take a payment?

RED FLAGS

- The demo uses features you'll never need, and skips the ones you use every day.
- It only works on one computer at the counter.

What good looks like: Everything you need on any phone, tablet or computer, and nothing you don't.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** Built for shops with ten technicians or fewer, on any phone, tablet or computer. Canadian shops in Canadian dollars, kilometres and HST, and US shops in US dollars, miles and sales tax.

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6 OF 10 · GROWTH

It helps you get customers

Shop software shouldn't only keep records. It should help fill the schedule, by letting customers find you and book without calling.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Can customers book online from my website, Google listing and Facebook?
2. Do online bookings land straight on my schedule, or in an email someone has to retype?
3. Can walk-ins check themselves in?
4. Is a website included, and can I update hours and prices myself?

RED FLAGS

- Online booking is a separate product from another company.
- Bookings arrive by email and have to be entered by hand.

What good looks like: Bookings from every channel go straight onto your schedule, with no retyping.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** Online booking from your website, Google listing or a QR code, walk-in check-in, and a shop website you can update from your phone.

7 OF 10 · WORKFLOW

It runs the whole day

Most shops buy software for one problem, then find they still need paper and spreadsheets for everything else. Check that it covers the whole day, from booking to the close.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Is there a live board showing where every car stands?
2. Can I see each technician's day, with hours booked against hours available?
3. Are repair orders, payments and balances owing in the same place?
4. Does it handle the cash drawer count at the end of the day?

RED FLAGS

- Separate systems for scheduling, repair orders and payments.
- No way to see who owes you money.

What good looks like: One place for the board, the schedule, repair orders, payments and the drawer.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** A live shop board, a day schedule per technician, repair orders, payments, balances owing and a daily drawer count, all in one place.

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8 OF 10 · QUICKBOOKS

It works with your accounting

"Integrates with QuickBooks" can mean almost anything. Ask exactly what moves between the two systems, in which direction, and how.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. What exactly comes over from QuickBooks: customers, balances, history?
2. What goes back to QuickBooks, and how: automatically or by export?
3. Will it work with the version of QuickBooks I have?
4. Will my bookkeeper be happy with it?

RED FLAGS

- A vague "we integrate" with no details.
- A sync that creates duplicate customers or entries.

What good looks like: A clear answer on what moves where, and a demo of it working.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** Customers and balances come over from a QuickBooks export in minutes, and the day's payments export back for your books.

9 OF 10 · HELP

Support from real people

Something will go wrong on a busy Monday. When it does, it matters who answers and how fast.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. When I call, who answers? Where are they?
2. What are your support hours? Is support included or extra?
3. How fast do you usually answer an email?
4. Can you make changes to my website for me?

RED FLAGS

- Support by ticket only, with no phone number.
- Paid support plans.

What good looks like: A phone number, real people who know the product, and support included in the price.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** Phone and email support from real people in Niagara, included in the price. We'll also update your website for you on request.

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10 OF 10 · THE TRIAL

Try it before you buy it

A demo shows you the best of the software. A trial shows you what it's like on a real Tuesday. Don't buy without one.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Can I try it with my real customers and a real week of jobs?
2. Do I need a credit card to start?
3. If I keep it, does my trial setup carry over, or do I start again?
4. Who can I call during the trial if I get stuck?

RED FLAGS

- A trial with sample data only.
- A credit card required up front, with charges starting automatically.

What good looks like: A free trial with your own data, no credit card, and help available.

> **How XSite Auto answers:** A free 14-day trial with your own customers and no credit card. Keep it, and everything you set up carries on.

PRINTABLE

Vendor scorecard

Score each vendor from 1 (poor) to 5 (great) on each section. Write the vendor names across the top.

WHAT MATTERS	VENDOR A	VENDOR B	VENDOR C
1. The real cost, not the monthly price			
2. Contracts and cancelling			
3. Your data stays yours			
4. Getting started			
5. It fits the way you work			
6. It helps you get customers			
7. It runs the whole day			
8. It works with your accounting			
9. Support from real people			
10. Try it before you buy it			
First-year total cost	$	$	$
Total score (out of 50)			

Five questions to ask on every demo

- What will I pay in total in the first year, in writing?
- Can I cancel any time, and download all my data when I do?
- Can you show me booking a job, writing it up and taking a payment, start to finish?
- Can I try it free with my own customers first?
- When I call for help, who answers?

Put us to the test

Bring this checklist to a 15-minute demo, or try XSite Auto with your own customers for 14 days. If it doesn't fit your shop, you've lost nothing.

$99 USD or $139 CAD a month after a free 14-day trial, with no credit card needed and no contract. Done-for-you setup is optional ($495 USD or $695 CAD, one time).

Start a free trial | **Book a 15-minute demo**

XSite Auto is a product of XSite Group Inc., Unit 5 - 165 Highway 20 W., Fonthill, ON L0S 1E5 · 905.346.0864 · david@xsitegroup.ca · xsiteauto.com · Serving owner-run businesses since 2011.